the same flight. With replacement fares far more expensive and her refund still pending, Mehta was forced to abandon the trip, despite having already paid for hotels and other travel reservations. Fares have escalated multifold, with the Abu Dhabi-Delhi route going up to around Rs 70,000, from Rs 10,000-15,000 earlier. The prices of India-US flights climbed from Rs 45,000-1 lakh to Rs 1.3 lakh-2.25 lakh, while Bengaluru-Frankfurt fares rose from around Rs 80,000 to Rs 1.9 lakh (see *How Fares Surged*).

LONG WAY ROUND

High prices, however, are only one part of the problem. The closure of airspaces has meant flights are now taking longer. Already barred from Pakistani airspace since Operation Sindoor in 2025, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) on February 28 announced additional restrictions, advising pilots to avoid 11 flight information regions covering Iran, Iraq, Israel, Syria, Yemen and parts of Saudi Arabia. Flights to Europe and North America that once overflew Pakistan and the Gulf have been pushed north and west through Central Asia, the Caucasus, Egypt and East Africa.

Thus, a Delhi-London flight is taking two hours longer as airlines avoid Iranian and Iraqi airspace, while some Europe-bound services are being rerouted via Africa. In March, a Delhi-Manchester flight returned to Delhi, having spent more than 13 hours in the air, after being denied overflight clearance in Eritrean airspace. Air India has introduced technical stops on some North America-bound services, extending Delhi-New York travel time from about 17 hours to roughly 22 (see *Detours in the Sky*). Technical fuel stops in Vienna, Rome, Copenhagen and Addis Ababa are also becoming increasingly common for long-haul aircraft operating near their payload limits.

The Pakistan airspace ban had already put Indian airlines at a competitive disadvantage. European airlines such as Lufthansa and Asian carriers like Cathay Pacific continue to operate shorter routes, while Indian airlines are forced to take longer, more expensive detours. These routes are increasing fuel burn by 1.3-1.9 tonnes per flight, while block times—total operation duration of an aircraft—have lengthened by 35-70 minutes per sector. Further adding to costs are war-risk insurance premiums on international operations, which have reportedly risen several times.

The consequent pressures have already

₹5,290 CRORE
Combined losses of Indian airlines in FY25, up from Rs 925 crore the previous year

55-60% ATF'S SHARE
in airlines' operating costs during April-May, up from 30-40% before the West Asia war crisis

16% RISE IN DOMESTIC
ATF prices per kl compared to the pre-war period

60-63% ATF PRICE HIKE
per kl for international operations (no government cap)

